

An Introduction to 3D Printing

Part 3: Science

*Vibrations and Waves, Linear Motion, and Thermal
Expansion*

Outline

Part 1: Printers

Process

Limitations

Dimensional Accuracy

Advantages

Part 2: Practical Application

Examples

Critical Thinking

Design

Part 3: Science

Vibrations and Waves

Linear Motion

Thermal Expansion

Vibrations and Waves

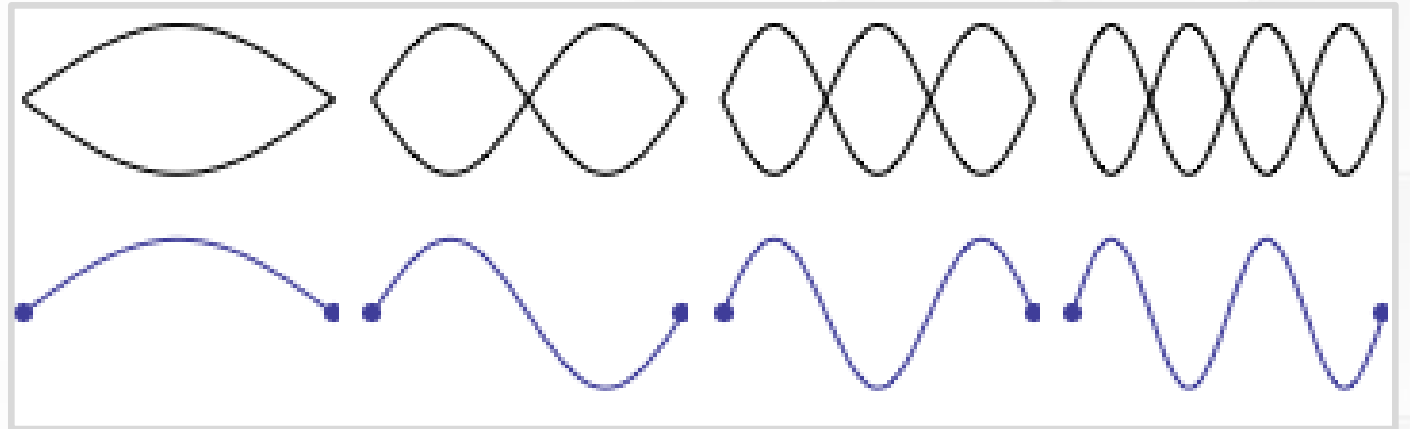
- Toolhead is attached to tensioned belts.
- Vibrations are created when the toolhead accelerates.
 - Speeds up.
 - Slows down.
 - Changes direction.
- Belts (strings) + vibrations (waves) = Physics.
- And what does Physics have to say?
 - Motions systems with belts have a dominant **natural frequency**.
 - Think of a guitar string playing a note.

Vibrations and Waves

- Toolhead excites the belts (adds energy) in the form of vibrations (waves).
- Waves travel along the belts.
 - They interfere and combine with each other.
- In most scenarios, waves interfere randomly.
- Destructive or inconsistent wave patterns.
- Vibrations stay small and gradually dissipate.

Resonance

- At the natural frequency, a special interference pattern appears.
 - Standing waves.
- Constructive interference.
- Vibrations align and add together.
- Resonance means vibrations grow much larger and last longer.



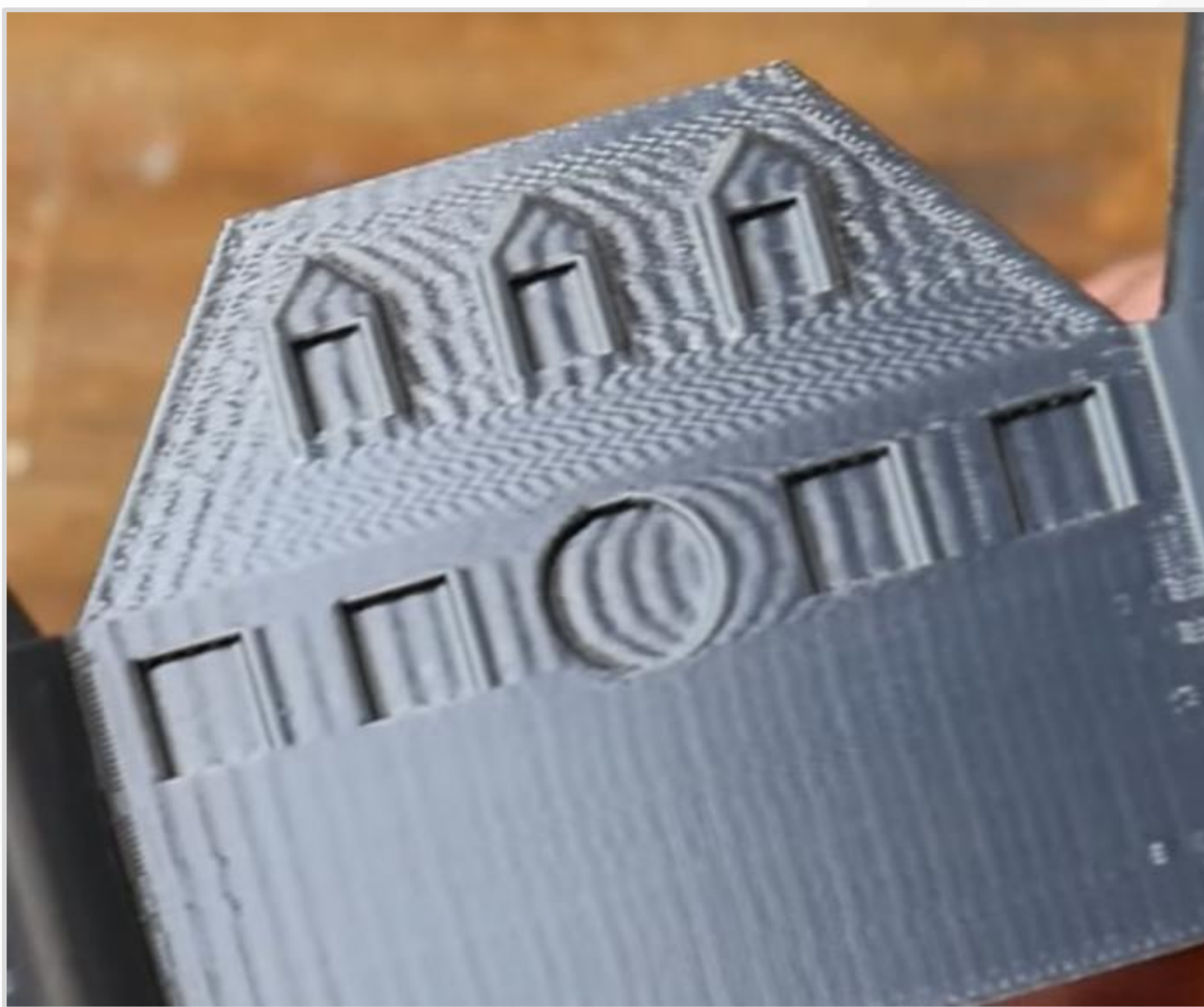
(Animation by Dan Russell)

Repeating Mistakes

- Resonance is bad for 3D printing.
- Vibrating belts push and pull on the toolhead → Small errors in nozzle position.
- **Errors repeat based on the frequency.**
- Imagine writing on paper with someone bumping your hand at regular intervals.

- Where do you see evidence of repeating errors?
- Sharp corners → Large accelerations → Large forces ($F = ma$).
- Which direction was the toolhead moving?
- From left to right.

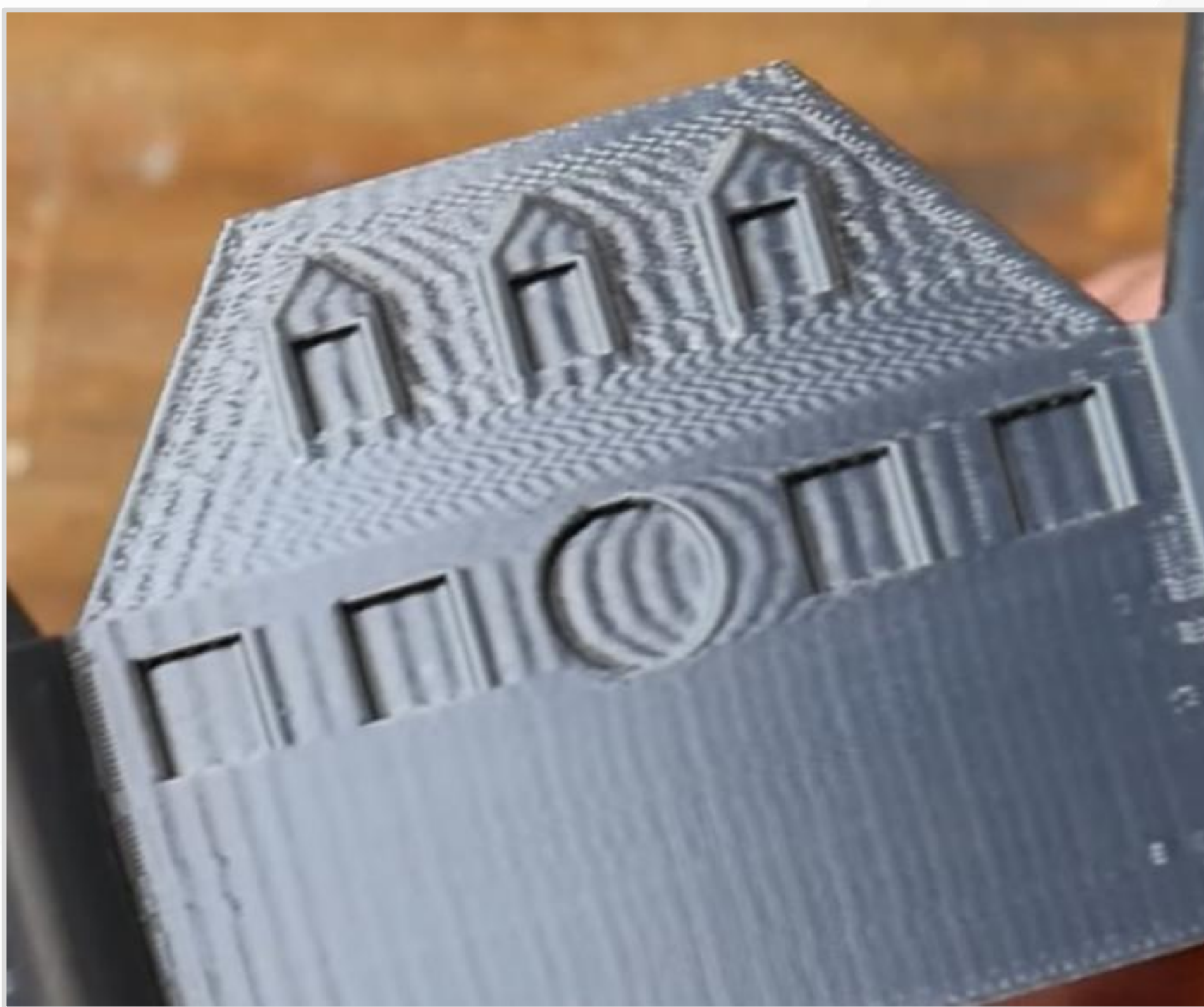
(Screenshot from
Teaching Tech)



- How can you determine frequency?
- Lookup printing speed in settings.
- Measure distance between repeating patterns.

$$freq = \frac{print_speed}{repeating_dist}$$

(Screenshot from
Teaching Tech)



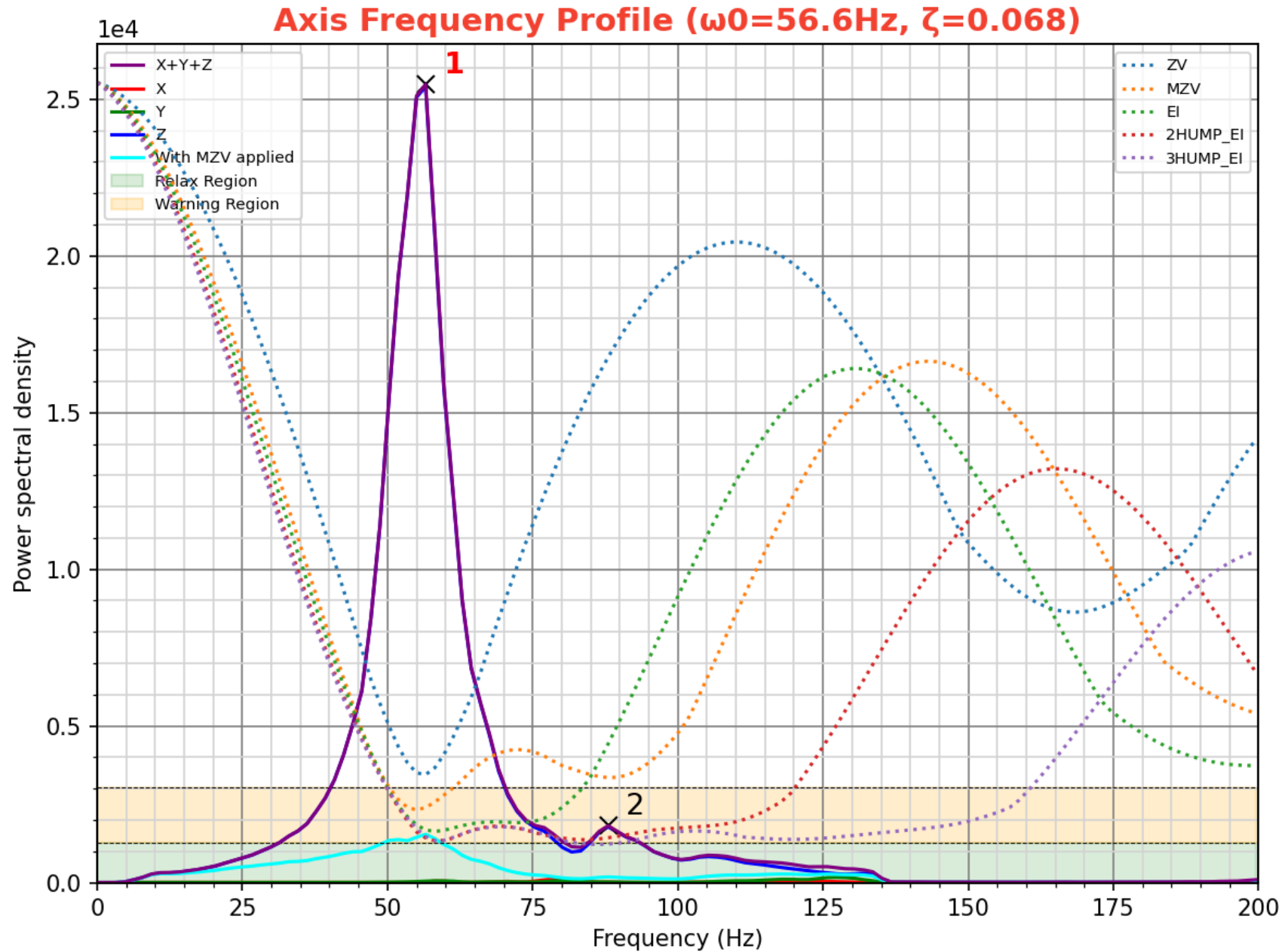
Input Shaping

- Add extra movements that cancel vibrations.
- Try to create destructive wave interference.
- Opposite of resonance.
- Similar to noise-canceling headphones.

(Animation, Demo by
ACS Motion Control)



- Shake and Tune Plugin.
- Move toolhead back and forth.
- Read vibrations with an accelerometer.
- **Purple** → Before
Cyan → After (Estimated)
- Single and narrow peak is easier to fix.
- Typical printing is less than 100 Hz.



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Speed Limits

I want to print faster.

- *Acceleration*: 10,000 mm/s²
- *Max speed*: 300 mm/s
- *Typical extrusions*: 0.4 mm wide, 0.2 mm tall
- *Max volumetric flow*: 22 mm³/s

Speed Limits

- How can I determine what to upgrade?
 - *Motors? Top speed or acceleration?*
 - *Max flow (heater and nozzle combo)?*
- What is the distance to accelerate to top speed?
 - Is it less than the print bed?
 - Is it less than the part size?
 - Is it less than a typical extrusion?
- How much filament can it melt at top speed?

Velocity and Acceleration

- What is the distance to reach top speed?
 - Starting speed (cornering speed, square corner velocity, jerk) is 5 mm/s.
- What is the smallest extrusion?
 - 9 mm to accelerate *and* decelerate.

$$v^2 = v_0^2 + 2a(x - x_0)$$

$$300^2 = 5^2 + 2 \times 10,000(\textit{dist})$$

$$\textit{dist} = 4.5 \textit{ mm}$$

Velocity and Flow

- Can my hotend melt enough plastic at top speed?
- *Almost, $275 < 300$.*
- Guess I should upgrade max flow.
- What if I change nozzles?
Extrusions are now
0.6 mm wide, 0.3 mm tall.
- *Even worse, $122 < 300$.*

$$print_speed = \frac{flow_rate}{cross_section}$$

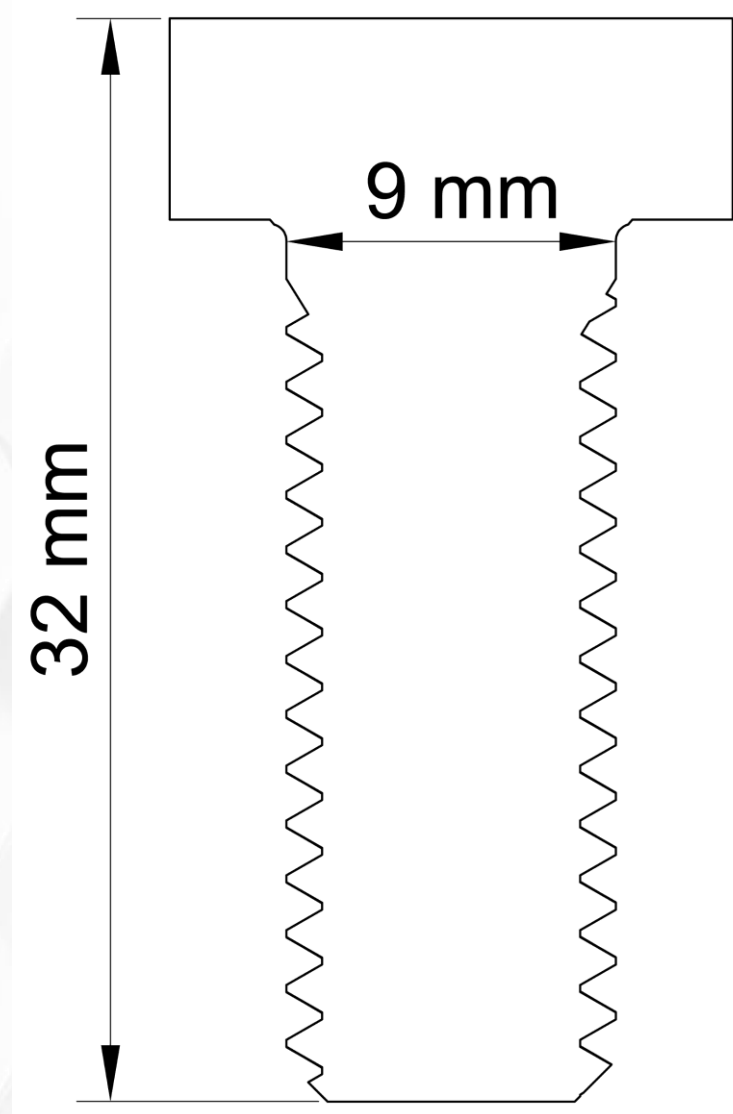
$$print_speed = \frac{flow_rate}{extrusion_width \times layer_height}$$

$$print_speed = \frac{22}{0.4 \times 0.2}$$

$$print_speed = 275 \text{ mm/s}$$

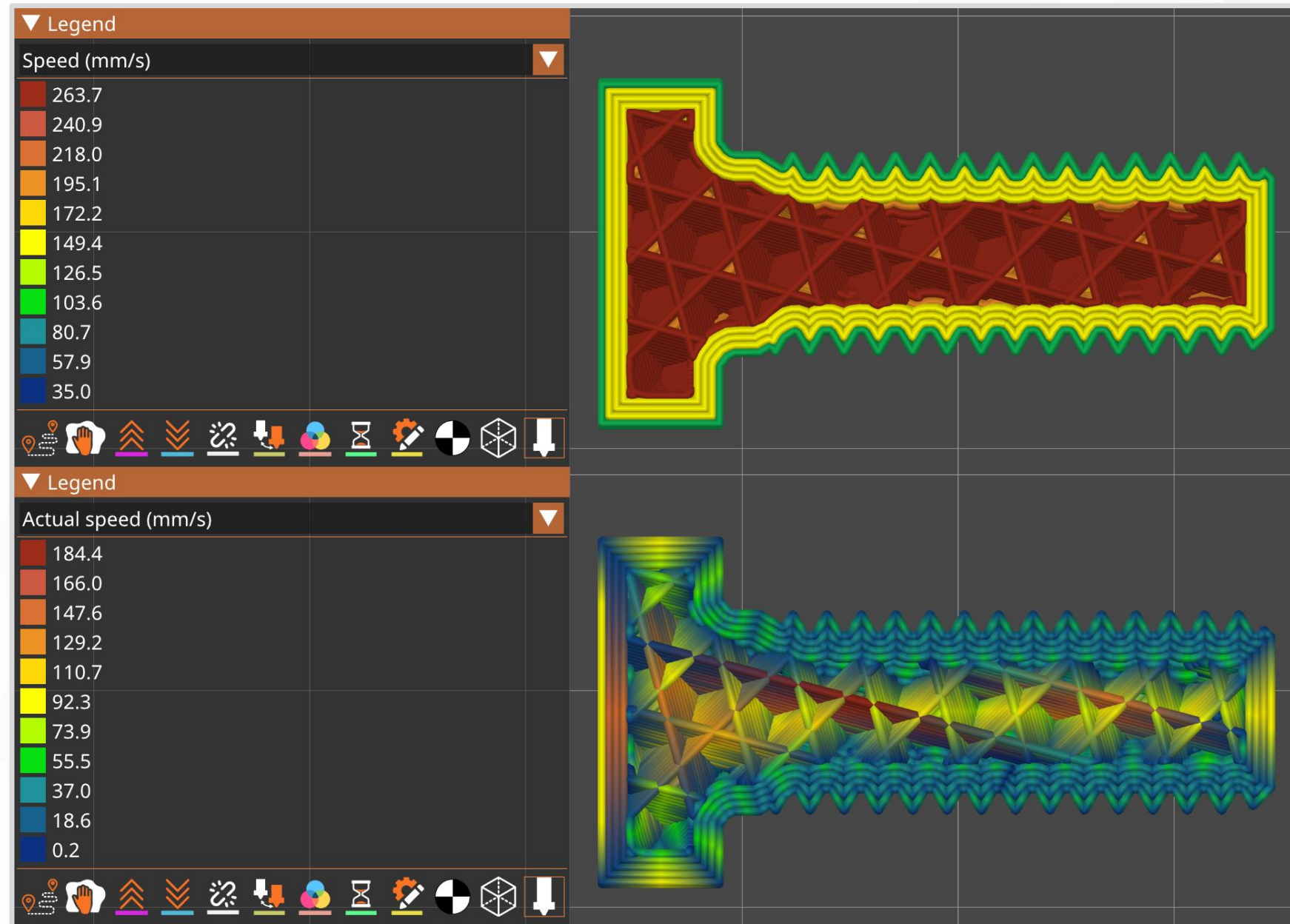
Finding Limits

- Real life limits are more complex and nuanced.
- *Example:* Printed bolt.
- What is going to limit my printer?
- Let PrusaSlicer do all the math!



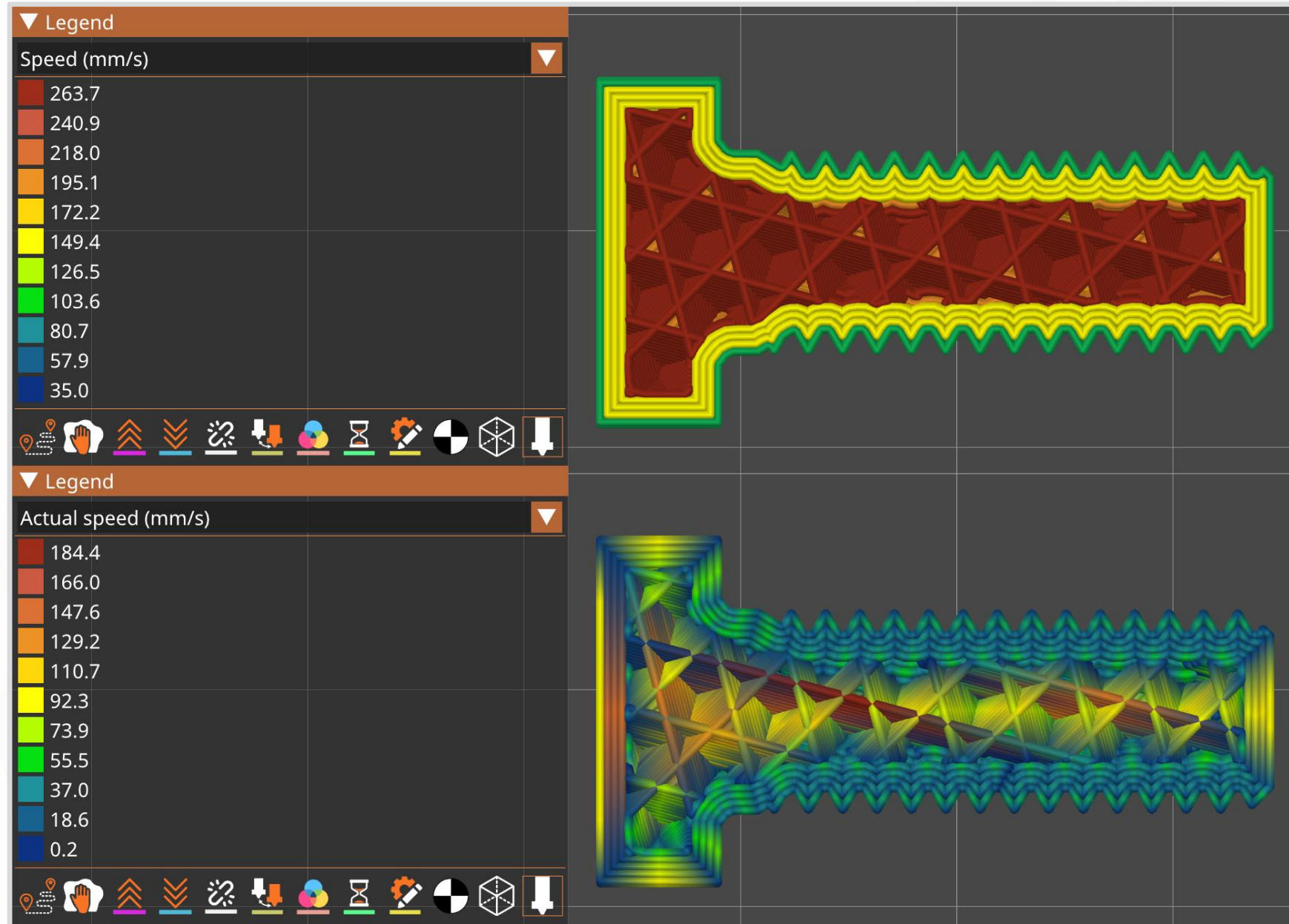
- Max requested speed:
264 mm/s
- Looks close to the estimate.

- Max actual speed:
184 mm/s



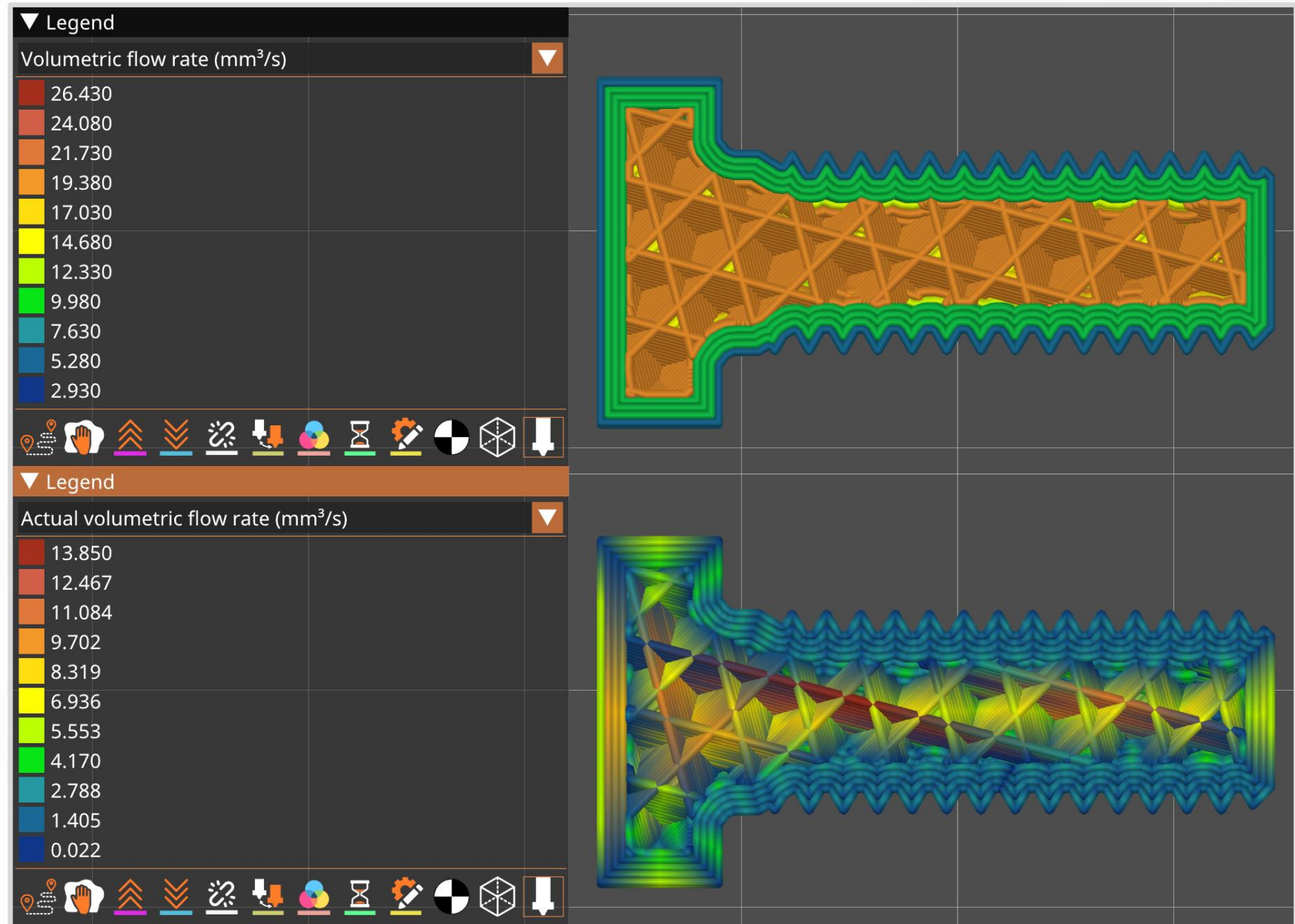
Why is the requested speed non-uniform?

- Adjust speeds according to geometry and **visibility**.
- Print slow on the outside to make pretty extrusions.
- Go fast on the inside to save time.



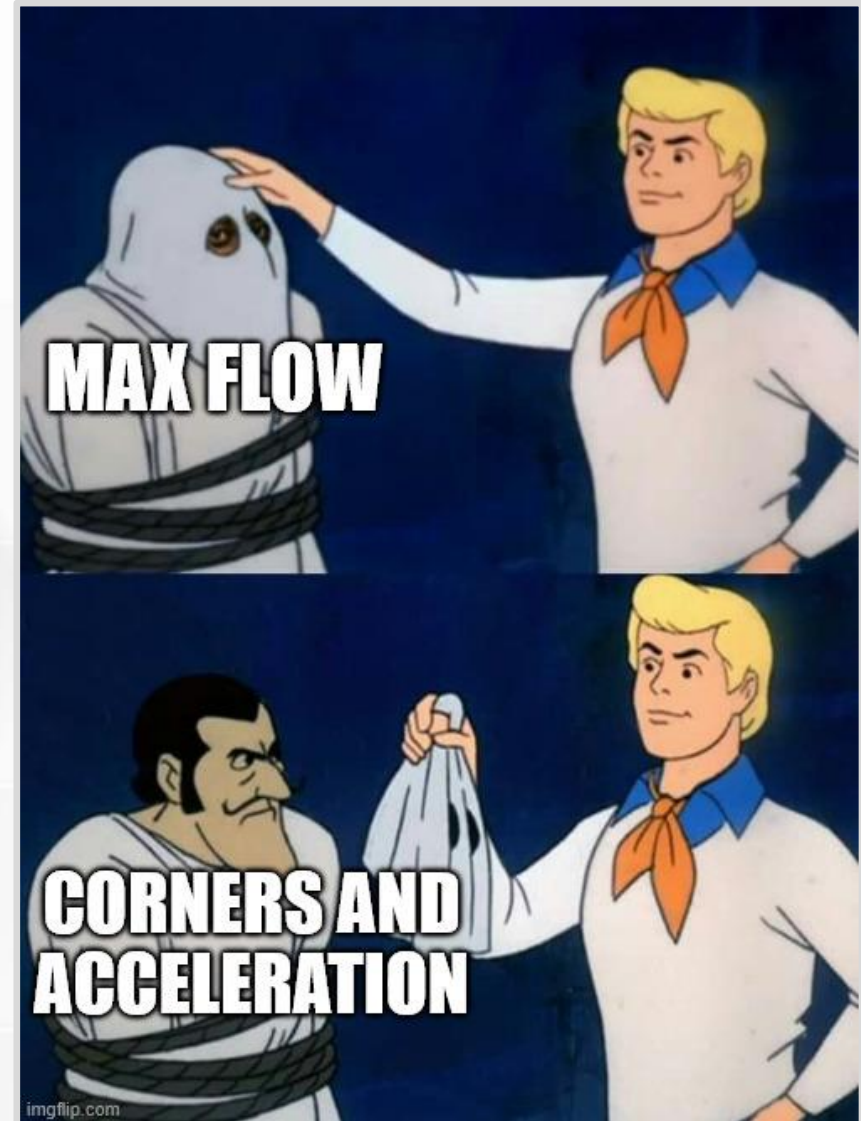
- Max requested flow:
22 mm³/s

- Max actual flow:
14 mm³/s



Speed Limits

- What is going on?
- My printer does not hit max speed, or max flow.
 - Max actual speed: $184 < 264$ mm/s
 - Max actual flow: $14 < 22$ mm³/s
- Limited by corners (geometry) and acceleration.



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Thermal Expansion

- Some materials expand as they heat.
- Coefficient of linear expansion.
- *Example:* Bridges use expansion joints to prevent gaps and buckling.
 - Between 1 inch and 1 foot.
- Is thermal expansion important for tiny 3D printer nozzles?

(Photo by Matt H Wade on [Wikipedia](#).)

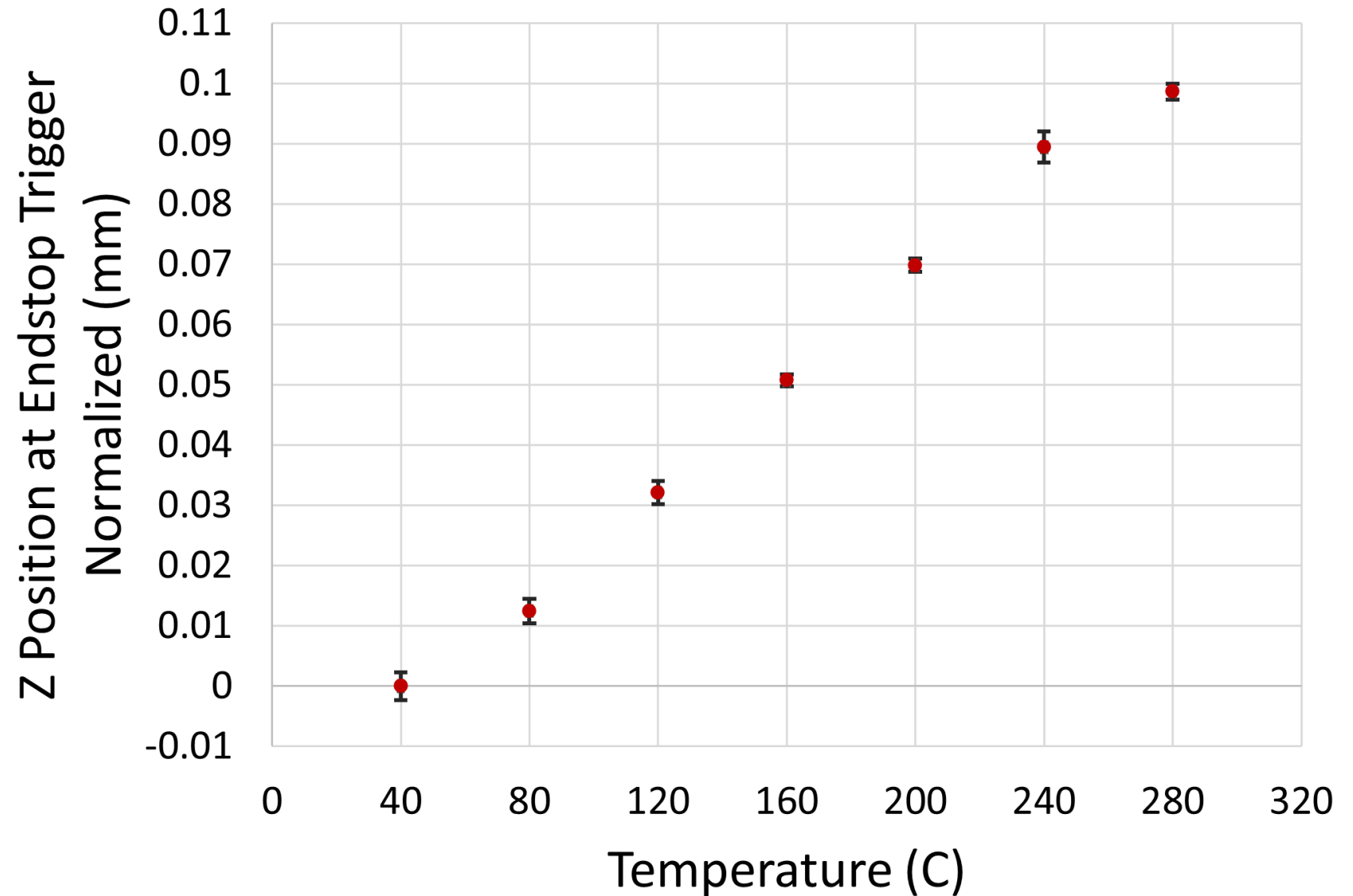


Thermal Expansion

- How much does a hot brass nozzle grow?
- Simplified estimate with a 12 mm cylinder.
 - $\Delta T = 150\text{ }^{\circ}\text{C} \rightarrow + 0.034\text{ mm.}$
 - $\Delta T = 300\text{ }^{\circ}\text{C} \rightarrow + 0.068\text{ mm.}$
- Is this large enough to affect the first layer?
 - **Yes, first layers are very sensitive.**
 - Well known from experience.

- Data from my own printer.
- Set temperature and wait 10 minutes.
- 19 samples per point.
- My printer uses two probes and calculates an offset → Normalized to zero.
- Error bars $\pm$ one standard deviation.

Thermal Expansion of a Brass Nozzle



Thermal Expansion

- What can you do about it?
 - “Heat soak.” Let everything heat up, expand, and wait for equilibrium.
 - Then probe nozzle position.
 - If you skip waiting, first layer is over-squished.
- Print beds need the same treatment.

Thermal Expansion

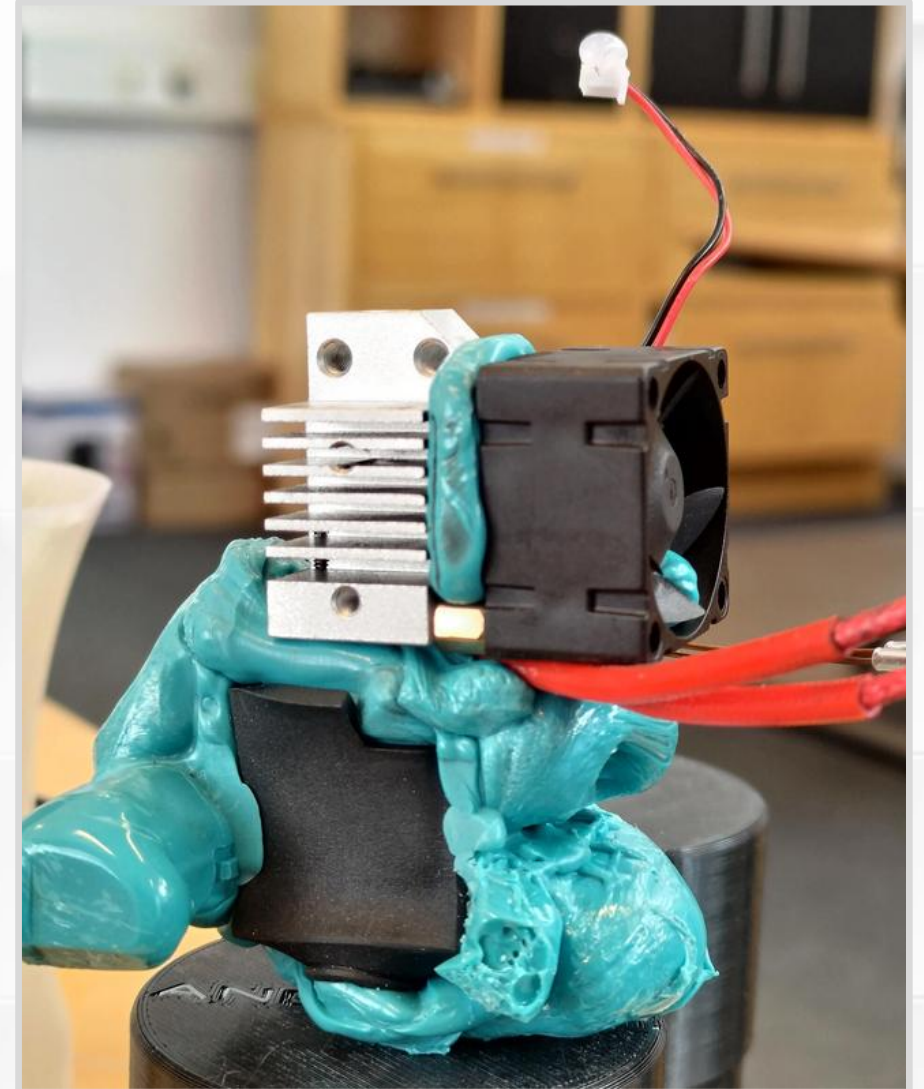
- Printers have lots of parts.
- What happens when they expand at different rates?



Thermal Expansion

- *Aluminum expands more than brass.*
- Imagine you screw a cold brass nozzle into a cold aluminum heater block.
- Unequal expansion at hot printing temps.
- Threaded hole expands faster than nozzle → A tiny gap forms in the threads.
- High pressure from extruding → Filament leaks out.
- “Blob of doom.”

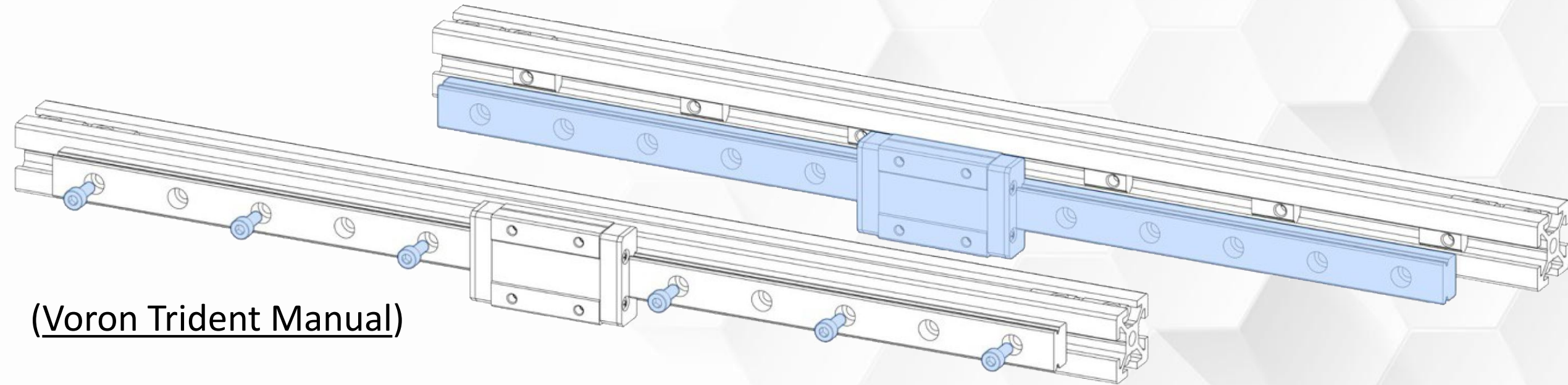
(reddit post.)



Bimetallic Strips

Consider the X and Y axis on a Voron 3D printer.

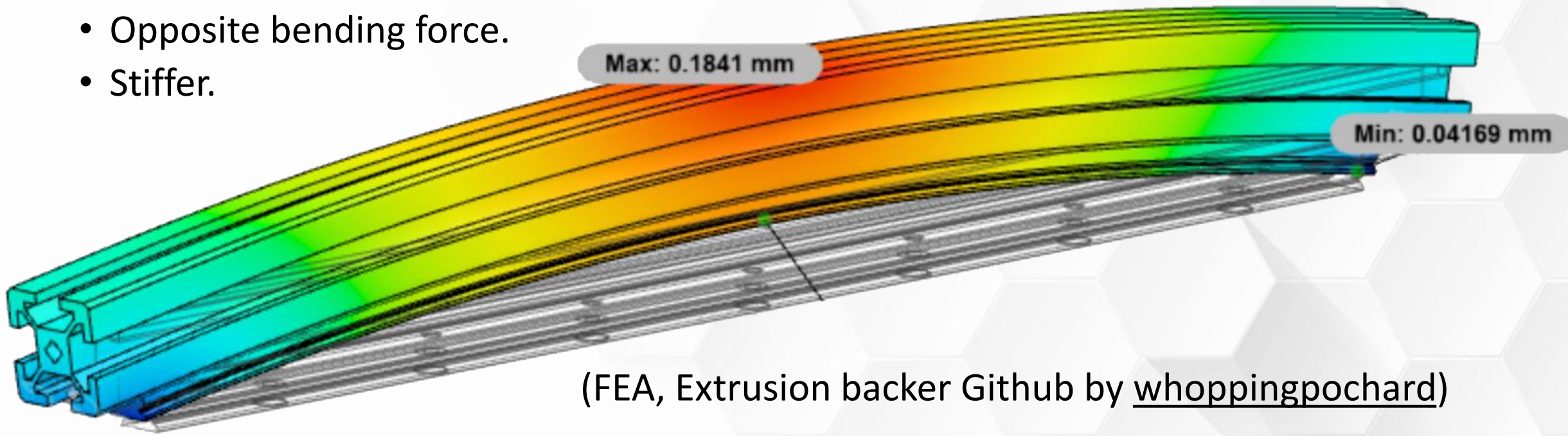
- Aluminum extrusion frame.
- Stainless-steel linear rail.
- Form a bimetallic strip (bar) when screwed together.



(Voron Trident Manual)

Bimetallic Strips

- *Aluminum expands more than stainless-steel.*
- Straight and flat at room temperature → Bow as temperature increases.
- Simulation for 300 mm beam, $\Delta T = 40^{\circ}\text{C}$. Almost 0.2 mm deflection.
- Fixed by adding reinforcing plate.
 - Opposite bending force.
 - Stiffer.



(FEA, Extrusion backer Github by [whoppingpochard](#))

